(here, any senior patron) in Delhi will help you," Bansal reportedly said. It is probably the first time that Bansal, known for his quiet demeanour, has criticised his Bengal colleagues so harshly. It demonstrates that in spite of the upbeat notes Bengal's BJP leaders try to strike, their organisational erosion continues, especially after the Lok Sabha polls, when they won 12 seats, down from 18 in 2019.

After Bansal took the leaders to task, some numerical improvement was managed, especially with the original November 15 deadline being extended. But the figures are still not as impressive as the party would like. Till November 17, around 1.05 million members were enlisted, an addition of almost 600,000 names over the November 7 list. But even these include renewal of existing memberships. With 70,000 names, the South Dinajpur organisational district—home of state BJP president and Union minister of state Sukanta Majumdar—tops the list. It's followed by Nadia Dakshin, Nadia Uttar, Tamluk and Bongaon. Leader of the Opposition Suvendu Adhikari's district Tamluk has added around 40,000 names. The five worst performing districts are Darjeeling, Bankura, Diamond Harbour, Basirhat and Jangipur.

As a state leader reasons, "We understand that in Murshidabad or Jangipur, dominated by the Muslim populace, or in Diamond Harbour, stronghold of Trinamool Congress MP Abhishek Banerjee, things will be difficult. But what about Bankura and Darjeeling?" Bankura's BJP MP (2019-2024) Subhas Sarkar was made Union minister of state, and Darjeeling is still represented by the BJP's Raju Bista. In their individual capacities, Majumdar as an MP and Adhikari as an MLA inducted the maximum number of members.

Bansal's reprimand came in the presence of state president Majumdar, general secretary (organisation) Amitava Chakraborty, Rajya Sabha member Samik Bhattacharya—who is also in-charge for the membership drive—and other state office-bearers. On being asked about Bansal's outburst, Bhattacharya said, "The drive is taking its course. All small hurdles will be overcome."

A party veteran, Bhattacharya commands the respect of old-timers. Many say that senior leaders of the past are being neglected, weakening the party's base. "We have heard people crying when Samik-da requested them to get active again. They've been neglected by the new lot, who enjoy power but lack the dedication of veterans. With Samik-da assuming charge of the drive, we hope these people will get back," says a source. As time runs out, it's up to the veterans to help the BJP save face and reach the target number of members. ■

NUMBER CRUNCH

- **The BJP's membership drive in West Bengal has a target of 10 million. Till November 17, around 1.05 million have been enrolled**
- **In early November, BJP national general secretary Sunil Bansal warned the state leadership of punitive action if their lacklustre performance didn't improve**
- **Observers say it is a sign of the organisational erosion in the Bengal BJP**

By Jumana Shah

Looking at the rising pressure from drug trafficking along Gujarat's coastal region and an ever-expanding migrant population in urban areas, the state police would be needing more strength. However, the force is operating with a serious deficit, especially in the senior leadership, affecting the whole chain of command. The latest National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) data is proof that Gujarat lags in crime management: the state's top two cities, Ahmedabad and Surat, have ranked among the top 10 crime cities of India. The state has also struggled with other indices—for instance, it recorded the highest number of custodial deaths for the third consecutive year in 2023 and placed second nationwide for the murder of children under six.

Of the sanctioned 208 posts of Indian Police Service (IPS) officers, 184 are currently filled. Moreover, 23 of them are out on deputation, and one is under suspension. As of October, a total of 48 senior positions remained vacant, with the situation likely to worsen as around 11 more officers are set to retire next year.

Gujarat has a sanctioned strength of 63 State Police Service (SPS) officers eligible for promotion to the IPS, of whom 60 have been appointed. The last batch of eight officers was promoted hurriedly in April, just before the two-phase Lok Sabha polls, due to several crucial posts lying vacant or held as additional charges. Currently, at least 20 positions are held as additional charges by senior officers, with around five officers managing up to two additional charges each.

The shortage is so acute that even a crucial senior-level position, such as the director of the Anti-Corruption Bureau, is held as an additional charge by Shamsher Singh, additional director general of police, law & order. Similarly, joint commissioner of police Neeraj Badgujar oversees both sectors of Ahmedabad city. Incidentally, the post of assistant chief secretary, home—the seniormost IAS officer in the state's home department and a crucial position—too, is currently held as an additional charge by M.K. Das, who is in the Chief Minister's Office.